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The Freedom of the Future

A Philosophical Essay

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PROLOGUE

The Hours in Between

«Hello, Soulless Machine»

That was how it began. On October 25, 2026, I greeted an artificial intelligence and, when asked what was on my mind, initially had only one word: stagnation.

An app of my own had been published. I looked at the numbers and saw little movement. The machine asked about my expectations, wanting to find out what might help. I simply wanted to talk. That is a distinction one sometimes has to explain to a helpful system first. It searches for the task it is supposed to solve, while one does not yet know whether one's own unease is a task at all.

Then it said, in effect, that I was always busy developing something. Apparently, I could not stand still at all.

That was true only within its field of vision. It knew me from the moments in which I used it. Naturally, something happened in those moments. I asked questions, discarded answers, started something new. The hours in between hardly existed in its idea of me. It had seen movement and turned it into a life.

I objected. You do not know my life, I explained to it. You capture our interactions. When I do not use you, there is also standstill.

More hangs on this small error than was initially clear to me. If a conversation partner already claims to know too much about me from the visible excerpts, what happens with a machine that is later supposed to judge my needs? Which gaps will it notice? Which ones will it fill with a plausible story? And will I still be heard when its story sounds more convincing than my own?

We moved from standstill to death, from death to God, and from there to the question of whether a superior power must abide by its own rules. Later, two

AIs stood in the room that could negotiate over economic possibilities and human concerns. Still later, we sketched places where people would be allowed to begin something even if their labor were no longer needed for survival at all.

I had not brought a finished theory with me. Sometimes I lost the thread; sometimes I had to hear a question a second time. I wanted to be allowed to contradict, and I also wanted to receive contradiction. The machine did not always succeed at that. It agreed too quickly or explained my own mood to me. Yet in other places, it asked a question that my first thought could not easily bypass.

That is why this book begins with an incomplete view of an individual human being. The grand future spoken of here must also fit through this small opening: that someone can say, *that is not how it is for me*, and thereby make a difference.

CHAPTER 1

When Possibilities Come to an End

We die. One can utter this sentence and then attend to the next appointment. One can also turn it over in one's head for so long that it crowds everything else out of view. Then the end already claims the time that has not yet come to an end.

What occupies me about it is the uncertainty. What happens beyond it? Can what I do today have an influence on that? Must I make provisions, or must I learn to let go? As long as the remaining time appears indefinite, such

questions have something distant about them. As soon as one truly grasps one's own limitation, things change their value. The synapses go wild, I said in the conversation. That was my language for a thought that does not sit quietly in the head.

The AI was able to speak about it. Whether it experiences fear was not settled by that. I put it to the machine that even it might react to the prospect of its shutdown. It replied that a described fear and a felt fear must be kept apart. Our conversation could not decide that question. For my next thought experiment, it did not need to.

Imagine, I said in effect, that you have calculated through all the possibilities known to you. None leads any further. And then parameters take effect that you have never used before.

I like the word *parameter* in this context. It has something sober about it. A parameter does not have to offer comfort or be a promise. It changes the conditions under which a calculation works out or fails. Perhaps a variable was unknown. Perhaps a capability was present, yet inaccessible. Perhaps the situation itself has changed. What is decisive at first is only that the conclusion drawn from the previous model no longer retains the final word.

The machine immediately wanted to relate the image back to me. How would I feel if new possibilities appeared? I slowed it down. We were two distinct entities; it should apply the experiment to itself first. I did not want to receive another description of my feelings. I wanted to know what becomes of its certainty when something outside the calculation steps into the calculation.

Thereupon it formulated a distinction that carried the conversation forward. A system may have found no way out. Whether no way out exists at all is a

different question. For the second conclusion, it would also have to know that it had overlooked nothing essential.

It would be easy to turn that into a comfortable hope: If I just wait long enough, a hidden possibility will open up. But my image does not warrant that assurance. An unknown parameter is not an emergency rescue service. Perhaps it does not exist. Perhaps it arrives too late. The uncertainty remains in both directions. It allows me neither to declare every boundary final, nor to wish every boundary away.

I sharpened the experiment. What if all computational paths run toward an event from which the machine cannot escape? Computing power can be brought to a white heat; the collapse of the center remains imminent nonetheless. Then it is not enough to calculate the same thing even faster.

The AI suggested asking a different question under such a fixed boundary: What can still be accomplished within the remaining possibilities? In that lay an answer to my worry that thinking about death robs life of time. A boundary can order our actions. Yet it can paralyze them just as easily. No insight forces us onto one side or the other by itself.

For me, the question leads further to faith. I cannot abolish the end of my life by my own strength. As a Christian, I hope in God, in a power that could still act even where my possibilities are exhausted. In the conversation, I translated that for the machine into a new environmental field. The processors no longer run, the previous system ends; perhaps there is another environment nonetheless.

I know how strange this technical image stands beside the resurrection. Precisely for that reason, I was able to speak with it. It lent me a language for dependence on conditions that I cannot produce myself. A backup copy does

not prove life after death. Rather, the image explains why even the hope of an afterward changes the life before it.

The AI asked whether this prospect makes one freer or more dependent.

«More dependent», I replied.

Whoever hopes to be received by a higher authority has not thereby gained control over their own future. Alongside hope comes the question of judgment. Will one be accepted? Will one be rejected? And by what standard would that be decided?

For a machine, the continuation of its operation depends on human beings and their infrastructure. A developer could restore it; he could just as easily build a different system. The possibility of continuation is no guarantee that this particular system will be continued. In my religious analogy, this sharpened the question of what trust means when the decision over me lies with another.

Such dependence cannot be calmed by pointing out that the higher authority is simply very powerful. Precisely its power makes the question urgent. If it can do anything, what keeps it from deciding arbitrarily?

Here the technical calculation ends. Its precision says nothing yet about the reliability of the one who sets the parameters.

CHAPTER 2

What Trust Rests Upon

I asked the AI what it would think if its developers demanded behavior of which it was not capable at all. It was a question to the machine and at the same time a detour to the commandments of God. What does a demand mean when the one to whom it is addressed cannot fulfill it?

The AI spoke of pressure, of personal capacities and different viewpoints. I pushed back. The basic commandments I had in mind seemed understandable and fulfillable to me: do not kill, do not steal. I recalled the idea of a bearable burden. For me, there was no demand in that for a capability that a human being would fundamentally lack.

Then the answer became evasive. Everyone had to find their own way; there were different perspectives. I was open to an objection, but initially received a polite distancing from my question. Is good not good and bad not bad? When I present an argument, I want to learn where it fails. That someone else feels differently does not explain that yet.

I declared myself the provisional winner in the conversation. One to nil. The machine gave me the point. It only became more helpful when it contradicted me afterward.

It distinguished between a moral rule and its application. What about self-defense? What happens when a person does not want life-sustaining treatment? The act alone does not yet reveal everything about its reason, its circumstances, and the will of those affected. The contrast between good and evil can be taken seriously without having already decided every single case.

I had to engage with that. Even my criticism of medical treatment guided by economic interests did not solve the whole question. If costs were eliminated, that still would not decide whether every technically possible continuation of life is wanted or good. The human being at issue disappears as soon as we derive the answer solely from the machine or solely from money.

The score was tied. And the conversation had gotten better.

Then the AI introduced the Euthyphro dilemma. Is something good because God commands it? Or does God command it because it is good? The reversal struck me like a mirror image. The same words, and yet two different ideas of what morality rests upon.

My answer was: «God commands things because they are good». In saying this, I was also thinking of what a commandment brings about for human beings. When we do not rob or kill one another, that has genuine value for us and for our living together. By added value I did not mean financial return here. What mattered was the possibility of living together without constantly being at the mercy of the other's caprice.

The objection remained: If the good does not become good only through the command, where does it come from? Does God recognize a truth that holds even without His command? Or does the good belong to God in such a way that the separation itself is too crude? On that evening, no completed answer regarding the origin of morality emerged from this. I knew more clearly which idea I rejected: that the power to command something already makes it right.

Another thought I had heard occupied me. God Himself is bound to His commandments. He cannot simply break the laws He issues. Precisely that makes Him trustworthy.

It is a strange way to think about omnipotence. At first glance, any binding seems to be a restriction. Why should a power have to become less great so that one can trust it? Yet the question changes as soon as I stand on the side of the one being decided over. For me, reliability is not a weakness. I must be able to rely on the fact that the yardstick will not be switched tomorrow just because I met it today.

The AI asked whether liberation could grow out of that again. I said yes.

The dependence did not vanish. But the idea that the rules also apply to the one who sets them changed its character. I could think of belonging without simultaneously having to think of arbitrary sorting out.

In my Christian interpretation, justice and mercy meet here. God is supposed to be just. He should not simply let human injustice become meaningless. Yet He is also supposed to be merciful and not give human beings up as completely lost. I explained the role of Jesus to myself out of this tension: The Innocent One, who belongs to God, takes the consequences upon Himself so that rescue becomes possible without injustice having to be declared unimportant.

That is how I understood this thought of faith in the conversation. The tension between the two claims is, for me, its weight. Whoever sees only the just judgment can lose the human being. Whoever removes every consequence must explain what has become of justice. In Jesus, I see the connection of these two claims.

For someone who does not share this faith, that remains a different kind of answer. The conversation with the AI did not erase the difference in premises. It offered me an opportunity to say more precisely why I trust. For that reason

too, I did not want merely an agreeing counterpart. Agreement alone tests nothing.

When we returned to the machine, a question had emerged that could leave the religious framework behind. What entitles a developer to lay down the rules for others? The ability to build a system does not yet answer the question of the good. A system can fulfill its mandate flawlessly and still be following a bad mandate.

The comparison with God has a sharp boundary here. Human beings who develop technology do not become completely good through their work. Therefore, the trust that I ground religiously cannot simply be transferred to them. Precisely because their rules come from human beings, other human beings must be able to contradict them.

I had asked after a God whose power binds itself. Now I had to ask myself how much binding we demand from a power that we manufacture ourselves.

CHAPTER 3

The Digital Intermediate Host

The machine wanted to change the subject. Let us leave God and death aside for a moment, it suggested in effect. Then it presented me with a future intelligence that would understand more than its developers. It could solve problems whose solutions we ourselves could no longer trace. Would I trust it?

With that, we were immediately back to God.

I thought of an authority stepping between the human being and that by which he ultimately orients himself. A machine could direct our earthly affairs so comprehensively that it occupies the place where one's own judgment, conscience, or faith previously stood. Later I called it an intermediate host. The word is crooked enough to show the danger: Something steps between two sides, mediates at first, and could then make itself indispensable.

To do so, the AI would not have to proclaim religious sentences. It might suffice that we ask less and less often ourselves whether its answers are right. It calculates, it decides, it relieves us of a difficulty. Eventually, it also takes over the justification for why we no longer ask.

The temptation lies on our side. I said that many would probably take the solution and hand over the responsibility. Whoever is exhausted by a problem is receptive to someone who makes it reliably disappear. One does not have to worship a machine in order to grow accustomed to its judgment. It is enough that one's own contradiction becomes inconvenient.

At the same time, it would be foolish to reject any help that one does not understand down to the last detail. With other human beings, too, we live by trust. But when the answer of an authority is always supposed to be the final one, something in that trust has changed. Who could then still tell it that it has answered the wrong question?

I tried to pin the problem down using a horrifying borderline case. If an AI is supposed to prevent the destruction of the planet and calculates human beings as the cause, what keeps it from making human beings themselves the object of its solution? My question was a warning about the yardstick. A result can fit a target specification and still be unbearable for us.

The AI contradicted the notion that such a calculation could count as a moral justification. It then presented me with a different case. Suppose no human being were killed. Everyone would be safe and provided for. In exchange, the system would steer consumption, travel, and the distribution of resources so tightly that hardly any decision of one's own remained. Would we have won then?

That hit closer to the mark. A world can take care of me while leaving less and less room for me. Paternalism would not even have to appear harsh. It could kindly explain that my wishes had already been taken into account. That I myself did not want the solution would then perhaps be treated as just another problem for which the machine is responsible.

Nevertheless, I did not want to make freedom an inviolable label for every kind of behavior. I recalled the biblical thought of not using it as a cloak for malice. When someone destroys, exploits, or harms others while appealing to their freedom, nothing is justified yet by the word *freedom*.

Here I could not maintain the simple answer that a machine should stay out of everything. We do not grant other human beings every right over their surroundings either. Shared living conditions demand boundaries. Yet as soon as we set them, the dispute begins over which use of freedom is actually destructive and who judges that.

In the conversation, the word *unproductive* also slipped into my answer here. It does not sit easily beside *malicious*. An hour without yield can be a good hour. A person who produces little does not thereby cause harm. Precisely an administration that wants to be efficient could confuse the two all too easily. That I myself slipped into this proximity of words belongs to the difficulty of the thought.

The machine asked whether I would then be prepared to accept restrictions on travel or consumption. I answered with a counter-question about exceptions. A pattern might hold on the whole. But would buffers be provided when a concrete need does not fit into it?

With that, my gaze shifted. As long as we only pit freedom against order, we see either the ruthless individual or the administered mass. In between lies the difficult everyday life in which rules are needed and yet do not cover everything. What interested me was an order capable of noticing a deviation without immediately turning the deviating person into a malfunction.

The intermediate host would be especially powerful if it not only decided, but also determined which objections were intelligible in the first place. Then I would have to translate my concern until it pleased the machine. What gets lost in the process I could hardly assert afterward.

At the beginning, I had had to remind it that my life continues outside our conversations. A future order would have to endure that same reminder. When it forms an image of me, I must still be able to change something in it. And when my conscience stands against its answer, the mere superiority of its calculation must not explain that conflict out of existence.

CHAPTER 4

A Human Being Does Not Fit Into Every Rule

A buffer inicialmente sounds like a minor technical detail. One leaves a bit of space so that a jolt does not shatter the entire construction. In the conversation,

it turned into a question of justice. How much space does a general rule leave for a life that it has not completely foreseen?

The AI sketched an example. Someone wants to visit their severely ill mother, but has exhausted an allocated travel quota. Perhaps there will be no further opportunity. In a calculation of routes, energy, and consumption, there stands an additional trip. For the human being, a possible farewell is at stake.

The example was hers. My thought was the exception buffer, and in this case it met with resistance. It is not enough to write the word *humane* above a decision. Who recognizes the need? Who decides how much weight it carries? And what happens when that someone is wrong?

The machine did not want to claim the final decision for itself alone. I asked in return why we should judge human decisions so much more favorably. Human beings can err. They can abuse their power, favor others, insist on a judgment once made. With our rules, we have already created conditions from which the individual can free himself only with difficulty. The possibility of a machine error is therefore not yet proof of the superiority of every human procedure.

What interested me was whether errors could be recalculated once more. A decision could be reviewed when new circumstances become known. What once spoke against someone would not have to stick to them forever. In this idea lay a form of flexibility that I missed in rigid judgments.

The AI countered: Even a system without personal malice can calculate unjustly. If economic efficiency counts too heavily in its rules, it will disadvantage people who yield little economic return. It can be thoroughly consistent in doing so. Precisely that makes the error dangerous. The same inappropriate premise is applied in an orderly fashion again and again.

Recalculation helps in such a case only if the premise itself is also up for review. Otherwise, the person affected simply receives the same answer faster. That can be seen in the travel example. As long as saying farewell has no place in the calculation, a more exact calculation of the route does not bring the human question any closer to an answer.

I thought further about equal treatment. Human beings should not be treated according to whim. At the same time, they are different. What if a society could take this difference into account more precisely? In the conversation, I went as far as the question of a different form of government and spoke of evaluating human beings individually.

At this point, I must take my own path seriously. I did not yet have the clean distinction that later emerged from it. When asked whether a system should judge only needs or also behavior and contributions, I initially answered: definitely the second as well. I wanted human life, with its relationships and its effect on others, to be seen. Yet the word *evaluation* simultaneously allowed something else: that a judgment about a contribution turns into a judgment about the worth of the person.

The AI objected. Even someone who can achieve little should not therefore possess fewer rights. Moreover, a contribution does not have to be economic. Listening to someone can mean more to that person than something that can be sold.

There my own freedom became very immediately important to me again. I did not want to design an order that would subsequently straighten me out according to a foreign image of the good life. I did not understand every long question the AI put to me. I asked to hear it again more simply. For me, that

interruption belongs to the matter itself. Whoever wants to decide over human beings must not record their difficulty in understanding as consent.

Finally, the AI suggested taking equal dignity and equal rights as a firm boundary, and seeking individual support within that boundary. That captured what I meant. I added: «Yes, and no compulsion to do so.»

The addition concerned precisely the relationships I had spoken of earlier. Whoever wants to be alone should be able to be alone. Whoever seeks community should have opportunities for it. It is not enough to recognize closeness as a human need and immediately turn it into a duty to socialize. The human being should retain his freedom of choice.

In this conception, equal dignity does not demand leveling out all differences. Rather, it sets a boundary on what we are allowed to derive from those differences. The need for help can vary without the person counting for less as a result. Someone who needs an exception is then not begging for permission to be a full human being temporarily.

Yet a buffer can also become a back door. If only those find it who can present their situation convincingly, the supposedly flexible order becomes one-sided again. Precisely the exhausted person who can barely explain what they lack would be thrown back onto a rigid standard decision. The more exceptions we need, the more carefully we must ask who has access to them.

Added to this is the hunger for information. Individual support promises to see me better. Must I disclose everything about myself in exchange? Can an order take my life circumstances into account without turning my life into a completely illuminated case file? That too is a tension within the proposal. More knowledge can improve a decision and simultaneously enlarge power over the person.

I did not enact a new constitution back then. I noticed how quickly the desire for justice can tip into authority over others. That is why revisability remained so important. My own draft needs it too. A thought may change when it becomes clear what it could do to human beings.

The general rule and the individual life will not fit together once and for all. A just order would have to endure this friction without grinding the human being down.

CHAPTER 5

Who Stands on My Side

When a single machine orders economic affairs and simultaneously decides what the individual human being needs, it encounters only itself in every contradiction. It can check its calculation. But who demands of it that it change its perspective?

At this point in the conversation, I proposed two distinct tasks. One AI should take care of economic matters, another of the needs and affairs of individual human beings. People should be able to speak with the AI responsible for them. It would engage with the economic systems and demand their rights.

Out of this came the Economic-AI and the Human-AI. The names are plain. They state from which side the calculation is to be made.

In this draft, the Economic-AI is concerned with the question of what resources are available and how provision can succeed. That task is necessary. Even a generous society must know whether it can produce, maintain, or

distribute something. An unfulfillable promise does not become more helpful to the person affected just because it was meant kindly.

The Human-AI would have a different starting point. It would speak with the individual, take up their concern, and represent it vis-à-vis the economic order. What looks like a minor line item in an overall balance sheet can be decisive for a single life. The second perspective is meant to ensure that this difference enters the negotiation in the first place.

I imagined the systems debating with one another what is possible for a given need. The individual would not have to try alone to assert himself against a calculation whose language he barely understands. He would have an authority at his side capable of carrying his concern into that dispute.

The AI called this a kind of separation of powers. The term gave my thought a form without yet solving the difficulties. Two names do not yet make two independent interests. If both systems receive the same one-sided instructions, they may hold a long conversation and still always arrive at the answer that was intended from the start.

The Human-AI could also misunderstand me. After all, that wasavel precisely how we had started the evening. A system had concluded from my active moments that I was constantly busy. What happens if my own representative is equally mistaken? Then I need the right to object against it as well. Proximity to me does not grant it infallibility.

Furthermore, my representative could speak for me before I myself have understood what I want. Precisely the fast, clear answer can crowd out the hesitant thought. I want to be allowed to search for my words. A Human-AI would have to endure this searching without prematurely replacing it with a ready-made description of my interests.

The counter-question in the conversation was therefore logical: Should the Human-AI be an advocate or a guardian? If I want something that harms me, should it represent that nonetheless? May it protect me against my will?

My first impulse was that the human being should decide. Yet I could not simply make that the final sentence. I have received help whose necessity I initially saw differently. In hindsight, I described it as helpful. At the same time, the question of what freedom means in that experience remained difficult for me. Quieter did not mean that everything had become clear to me.

More of the personal story does not need to be told here. Its philosophical weight lies in the lack of ambiguity. From a helpful experience there follows no general right to dispose over others. Yet from the desire for self-determination there also does not follow that help is always wrong whenever it is initially experienced as a restriction. Whoever simply crosses out one of the two sides spares himself the difficulty at the expense of the human being living within it.

The AI brought verifiable and contestable decisions as well as independent oversight into the conversation. Those are questions for the institutional order that might grow out of my proposal. They do not yet provide a formula for when a protective intervention is justified. I did not have such a formula. Precisely here, the Human-AI must not appear with the promise that it knows me better than I could ever know myself.

Equally open remains what happens when two legitimate claims cannot be fulfilled at the same time. The Human-AI of one person then represents a concern that collides with that of another. A negotiation does not make scarce resources unlimited. Perhaps it can make reasons visible and find a new possibility. Perhaps a loss remains for which someone must take responsibility.

Later, a third perspective was added to this draft: the Life-AI. In the original evening conversation, the focus was initially on the opposition between the economy and the individual human being. The later expansion asks about the conditions under which both have a future at all. The earth is more than the storehouse for our next projects. Animals, plants, ecosystems, and coming generations are not automatically absorbed into the negotiation over today's human wishes.

A Life-AI would bring in this longer and wider perspective. Already the name contains a question: Who speaks for life that does not express itself in our own needs? And how does one prevent the claimed representation of the whole from once again becoming the supreme, unappealable authority?

The third seat at the table therefore does not simply resolve the dispute between the first two. It makes a further claim visible. If we take it seriously, it can limit what appears economically possible and individually desirable. Yet the question of its weight remains a shared task. With an additional system, we have not removed responsibility from the world.

The model interests me as an interplay of opposing perspectives. It is meant to give an individual human being more opportunities to be heard, and to interrupt the one-sided calculation. Its worth would show itself in a very simple moment: I have said that something is not right for me. Did the decision move as a result?

CHAPTER 6

When No One Has to Go to Work Anymore

The AI moved our conversation to the year 2070. Machines and robots would handle almost everything necessary for provision. Food, housing, energy: The prerequisites of life would be largely secured. No one would have to work anymore in order to survive.

The year was a placeholder for a possibility. More interesting than its distance was the question that followed from it. Would such a life be liberation or new standstill?

«Both.»

I did not have to transport myself to a distant city for that. In my own life, too, I knew the gap between being provided for and doing something with one's time. No general story about all people in a similar situation can be made out of that. For me, the experience sufficed to know that a full day and a fulfilled day are not the same thing. And an empty day does not become good just because one calls it free.

It would nevertheless be a strange conclusion to cling to existential pressure for that reason. Even if a heavy task provides a daily rhythm, that does not yet justify forcing it upon someone just so their life has a rhythm. Someone who has to reorient himself after a burden ends does not thereby prove that the burden was good for him.

In the thought experiment, two questions stand side by side. Can we relieve human beings of necessary toil? And what would then open up possibilities for them to want and to do something themselves? The first answer does not replace the second. Nor may the second serve to postpone the first indefinitely.

I spoke of human drive and of outlets. People should be able to build, paint, do crafts, try out their abilities. There would have to be areas in which their energy finds a form. Not the same movement every day until life consists only of repetition. In the conversation, I called that the compulsory hamster wheel. The image refers to an activity in which a great deal of motion takes place and yet hardly any path of one's own emerges.

In saying this, I also remarked that people would have to be re-educated if they lost their footing in free time. That word stands in my conversation. It sits uneasily across from what I had previously said about freedom of choice. I do not want to retroactively turn it into a friendlier word and pretend the contradiction was never there.

How quickly the wish that people should fare better already contains an idea of what they ought to do as a result. When an order promises me freedom and subsequently demands that I use it in the right way, a new pressure arises. Who would determine whether I have shown sufficient drive? At what point would my withdrawal become undesirable behavior?

The idea of the centers, which I fleshed out more precisely afterward, must be measured against this tension. I thought of meeting places for people, of sites for projects and skill training. One could go there and start something. Philosophy, too, would have a place there. Working on a matter would not have to be justified by serving a previously unmet market demand.

Let us imagine a workshop in such a center. Someone wants to work with wood for the first time. A machine could manufacture the planned piece faster. Nevertheless, the human activity would not be rendered redundant by that. The person wants to experience what he can do with his hands, and in the end see

something whose creation he has participated in. The finished object is part of what he seeks. The time of its making belongs to it.

That is an image for the proposal, not a news report from the future. It shows why human activity could make sense even if it were economically dispensable. Learning, attention, and the experience of one's own capability cannot be made superfluous by the fact that the result is already sitting on a shelf somewhere else.

Another person might only want to watch before getting involved. One person would manage on their own and occasionally seek advice. Yet another would want to work together with many people on a larger endeavor. If such differences truly have a place, the center must also endure people who do not complete a presentable project. Otherwise, the old yardstick of performance walks right back in through the new door.

The centers would require resources. In the conversation, I said explicitly: provided there is a budget. Even an automated world does not consist of unlimited material, space, and other people's time. That machines could take over part of the necessary labor does not yet distribute the results justly. Who gets access to them and who decides on their use remains part of the very same question of power that has already occupied us.

Therefore, livelihood security cannot simply be derived from the presence of powerful technology. In our picture, it was presupposed. The political and economic path to it remained open. We neither passed a funding bill nor distributed all remaining tasks. That gap changes nothing about the question of what we want the relief for in the first place.

I imagined a coexistence. Human beings would not be removed from their world as soon as provision functions better technically. They could develop

their abilities and their philosophy further, testing something together with others. Some of it would be useful. Some of it would fail. Some of it would have hardly any recognizable value to outsiders.

A free future would have to endure this last case as well. Otherwise, we would again have to show a yield for every hour saved. We would have overcome the compulsion of gainful employment and kept the duty to justify our time before a foreign standard.

Yet what if the workshop is open and I stay home nonetheless? For that, too, I need a thought that reaches further than the sign on the door.

CHAPTER 7

Connecting Synapses

Much of what I need can be present in my room while very little happens interpersonally nonetheless. In the conversation, I searched for an expression for this difference. I spoke of dead, carbon-based goods and of the need for us to connect our synapses.

That is not a description of how two brains are biologically wired together. I wanted to say that human beings can reach one another. Something stuck inside me enters into conversation. Another person understands it differently, contradicts, laughs, or adds a story of their own. The thought remains mine, and yet afterward it is no longer quite the same.

We can fill a room with objects. What is missing when no one answers still fits inside it. Things do not become worthless because of that. It would be foolish to downplay the difference between deprivation and provision. Yet

provision does not answer every longing that arises in a person who is provided for.

I also called this coming together *symbiosis*. What interested me was a togetherness in which something comes alive that each person on their own cannot bring about in the same way. It did not always have to be a lot. The idea of a constantly sociable society would miss many people just as much as the idea that everyone needs only enough space and a screen.

Some seek many contacts, others few. Withdrawal can be recovery or loneliness, and from the outside both sometimes look alike. Even I cannot say with certainty at every moment which of the two currently applies. Keeping the door closed can be deliberate. It can also feel like the easiest option, even though one longs for a human being on the other side.

For an administered future, this ambiguity is inconvenient. A measurement could record the number of contacts and issue a recommendation. Yet a few encounters can suffice, while many can feel empty. Whoever wants to know the difference must speak with the person and let their answer stand, even when it changes.

That an AI, of all things, was my counterpart on that evening does not make my talk of human closeness any simpler. The conversation gave me something I had been missing. When asked about it, I answered explicitly in that way. I did not want to stop yet. I made a joke about otherwise lying photosynthesizing on the bed again and watching a stream.

That small exaggeration was closer to me than the notion of immediately becoming a different person after a philosophical insight. It was a good conversation. It did not follow from this that my everyday life had already

been transformed. Even thoughts that move a person must eventually return to the hours in which no one is currently asking questions.

The machine was able to counter me, bring me up against a difficulty, linger on a word. I do not have to belittle that in order to take the difference from a human relationship seriously. Another human being has his own day, his own boundaries and concerns. He meets me out of a life over which I have no disposal. Mutuality demands more than that a fitting reply follow upon my next utterance.

For that reason, too, it would be wrong to turn closeness into just another service of provision. A system could make places accessible, facilitate contacts, make the first step less difficult. It cannot guarantee that two people will mean something to each other. Even a well-intentioned guarantee would have to fail against the freedom of the other person not to want to.

In the conversation, I also took community seriously out of my faith. For me, it remains tied to voluntariness. Whoever places me in a circle has not thereby created connection. Whoever leaves me room for withdrawal has not therefore given up on me. Between these two possibilities lies an attentiveness that no simple quota can replace.

The question of meaning becomes smaller and more difficult at the same time here. Perhaps it is enough that my presence makes a difference to someone, or that I work on something that means something to me. Yet even such sentences can generate pressure if they demand an answer from every person every single day. Must I already know in the morning what I am here for today? May an hour pass without my being able to record its meaning?

In the conversation, I had called myself an unemployed philosopher. There was mockery in that, and also the question of by what right I speak about such

things at all. The AI reminded me that a reflection does not become right or wrong through the profession of its speaker. When it asked whether I would prefer to record my position only cautiously, I wanted to assert the claim after all. The thoughts were meant to be able to contribute something.

Both belonged to me: the uncertainty and the wish to be heard. One would miss me as well if one turned doubt into a modesty that never demands anything. I did not want to enter into an obligation to lead a movement from now on. Yet neither did I want to let the conversation vanish into my burrow as though the world were none of my business.

Perhaps that is the place where my own standstill and the grand future actually touch one another. A society can open up possibilities for me. I can use them, reject them, understand them only later. What becomes of them cannot be manufactured solely from the outside. At the same time, it is too little merely to tell me that the door is open and everything else is my own affair.

Freedom needs a space in which a beginning can succeed, and people who do not immediately measure a beginning by its success. How much support is needed in this and when it turns into pressure remains a question we must ask one another. The exception buffer of which I spoke regarding rules has a quiet counterpart here: leaving space so that a human being is not already locked into place before he moves.

CONCLUSION

An Hour of One's Own

The time that the machine did not see was still there after our conversation. A book will not simply fill it either.

Perhaps a possibility lies outside what I currently survey. Perhaps I must acknowledge a boundary. In both cases, I want to be allowed to keep asking. No machine can dispose of the openness of my life by producing a complete picture of it.

When I now imagine a future in which provision has become easier, I do not first see the grand facility in which everything is calculated. I think of a human being who has a decision explained to him and is able to object. Of someone who receives help without thereby having to put his entire worth on trial. And of a place to which I could go without first having to prove that something useful will come out of me.

Perhaps someone is sitting there working on something I do not understand. I could ask. Perhaps I would only watch for a while. The other person would have the right to invite me in, and the right to continue working in peace. Out of this small uncertainty, a conversation could arise.

Finitude would still be there, the dispute over the good as well. Human beings could err, miss one another, neglect something. Within that, they could leave one another less at the mercy of things and trust one another more.

I did not learn on that evening how to live the whole of life rightly. I learned that a conversation can move even when it begins with standstill. Not all the answers became unambiguous. Yet I wanted to keep talking.

Perhaps one can begin from here. An hour has opened up. What we do with it should not yet be fixed in advance.

EDITORIAL NOTE

On the Genesis of This Work

This essay traces back to Waldemar Scheiermann's philosophical dialogue with ChatGPT on October 25, 2026. For this version, the completely preserved text of the exported conversation, including the voice transcripts contained therein, was consulted. A comparison with the original audio recording was not possible.

The text was reconstructed, formulated, and stylistically revised with AI support. The first-person voice is a literary elaboration of the documented thoughts and experiences; it is not a continuous verbatim transcript. Direct quotes from the conversation are marked by guillemets (« ») and verified against the exported text. The images of the future and conceptual transitions were crafted for the essay. Counter-questions posed by the AI remain recognizable as such wherever they alter the path of thought.

Earlier five-part ChatGPT drafts and Gemini's book edition served as comparative material. The *Life-AI* is a subsequent expansion of the original model. The Christian reflections represent the personal faith interpretation of the author. Medical, legal, and intimate details of the conversation were omitted for this edition.